Roland Freisler. The fruit of the prosecutor's labours was a twelve-page appreciation with three annexes, outlining why Erich – along with Bruno Baum, who had also been apprehended – was a danger to the state. Throughout the session, Honecker sat silently, his eyes wide open, his head sometimes cupped in his hands. That morning, the court handed him a sentence of ten years penal servitude for the 'preparation of high treason alongside the severe falsification of documents'. Trembling like a leaf, Baum was passed a twelve-year stretch, while the luckless Sarah Fodorovä, the Czech girl with the suitcase, was released.

After judgment, Honecker – marked prisoner 523/37 – was moved to Brandenburg-Görden prison, a hulking behemoth hidden in thick fir forests to the west of Berlin. Known as the 'German Sing Sing', this multi-story structure grouped around courtyards, could hold 1,800 inmates, making it the largest penal institution in Germany. 'A few of the supervisors treated the political prisoners with the utmost brutality,' Honecker said. 'Conditions regarding food, sanitary facilities and health were often appalling.'2 Discipline was administered by warders made up of old Nazi fighters absorbed into the state after Hitler's appointment.

In the seven years that followed, Honecker's relations with fellow inmates were generally good; however, his commitment to the KPD cause remains a matter of conjecture and speculation. Despite strict isolation and surveillance, inmates formed an illegal KPD group to organise resistance and unite imprisoned anti-fascists. The saying, 'Where there is a comrade, there is the party' became well known. The KPD grapevine kept inmates posted on developments from the outside world, such as Hitler's march into the demilitarised Rhineland in 1936, the annexation of Austria, the Sudeten crisis, and the vicious pogroms against the Jews.

Once released from isolation, Honecker moved into a three-man cell in 'Building 2', and after the outbreak of war in 1939, good behaviour earned him the position of a Trusty, a role he committed himself to wholeheartedly by serving the prison doctor, Johannes Muller. According to former colleague Heinz Lippmann, many prisoners described Honecker as being reserved, 'snotty', and showing few signs of solidarity. (For his part, Honecker looked back on these years as a time of unity, fellowship and